

The Iron I Settlement Wave in the Samaria Highlands and Its Connection with the Urban Centers

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The archaeological and historical study of the “Early Israelite” settlement of the Iron I period in the southern Levant culminated in the early 1990s (Dever 1995; Finkelstein and Naʿaman 1994; Finkelstein 1995, 1996). Novel and revolutionary theoretical thinking in archaeology was brought in as a framework for new explanations and interpretations of old and new material. Socioeconomic transformations (as opposed to migrations) were sought when attempting to explain the “sudden” appearance of hundreds of sites in the highlands

of the southern Levant (west and east of the Jordan). The new theories proposed tracing the source of the “early Israelites” to the nomadic society that had lived in the highlands for generations, or to refugees fleeing from the Canaanite urban society. These theories were unique in the fact that they offered an alternative to the migration models based mainly on the books of Joshua (military conquest) or Judges (peaceful infiltration) that had prevailed for many years.



Tel Megiddo, the Jezreel Valley and the northern Samaria hills. Photograph courtesy of Israel Finkelstein and the Megiddo Expedition.



Figure 1. Surveying the eastern outskirts of the Samaria Highlands. Adam Zertal's survey of the northern Samaria Highlands recorded scores of previously unknown sites. Photograph courtesy of Shay Bar.

However, no matter how revolutionary these theories were, one fundamental concept was common to all of them: their basic assumption that the settlement of “Early Israel” was a reaction to and outcome of the collapse of the Canaanite urban centers—a downfall that took place at the end of the Late Bronze Age and as part of the “collapse of all civilizations” that was taking place across the board (Ward and Joukowski 1992).

In what follows, I wish to ask if that is necessarily so? Can we recognize in the archaeological data a wholesale destruction of all Canaanite centers and an era of a village-based society that lasted two hundred years all across the land? As will be demonstrated, the ever-growing archaeological data of the twelfth through tenth centuries BCE from regions such as the coastal plain, and the Jezreel, Jordan, and Hula Valleys call for a reevaluation of this scenario.

History of Research

The archaeology and history of early Israel owes a great debt to Albrecht Alt, who was the first to adopt a long-term perspective

in his research into the settlement process of the Israelites. Based on textual criticism of the Bible and other contemporary Near Eastern sources such as the Amarna Letters, Alt hypothesized that the Israelites slowly settled into the vacant land of Samaria and the Judean hills. To verify Alt's hypothesis there was a need to study the land between the cities, to implement surveys of small-scale settlement sites, and to excavate one or two of them. The first generation of explorers, however, chose to excavate the main sites, that is, Shechem, Tel Dothan and Ta'anak, and thus were only able to expose the nature of the Canaanite urban centers during the Middle and Late Bronze Ages, but their contributions to understanding the rise of Israel was limited.

It was only with the publication of the “emergency survey” conducted in the Samarian and Judean Highlands (Kochavi 1972) that scholars were able to identify numerous Iron I sites that had never been documented. Kochavi was quick to realize that the study of these sites could add considerably to our understanding of the settlement of the Israelites in the core region of Samaria. As time progressed, new surveys were initiated and two major regional projects were conducted in the southern



Figure 2. Excavations at the site of Shiloh (1981–1985). Photograph courtesy of Israel Finkelstein.

and northern Samarian Highlands (fig. 1; Finkelstein 1994; Zertal 1994). Both works identified a significant surge in the number of sites and dated it to the twelfth–tenth centuries BCE. While Zertal tied this swell to the immigration of the “Israelites” into the region, most scholars acknowledged the fact that the new sites were not the result of an organized immigration as described in the Book of Joshua. Alternatively, archaeologist and biblical historians were looking for an explanation that saw this increase as the result of internal social processes. Finkelstein noted the fact that the Iron I settlement wave was not unique and should be explained in light of two earlier waves dating to the EB I and the MB II. This brought him to the realization that changing sociopolitical and economic circumstances placed pressure on the highlands population to adapt their subsistence strategies and to shift or oscillate between nomadism and sedentarization. More specifically, in regard to the Iron I, Finkelstein asserted that the collapse of the urban centers at the end of the Late Bronze Age meant that the economically specialized nomads of the highlands lost their markets. Consequently, they had to settle down and develop a mixed economy based on herding, agriculture, and horticulture. Other scholars at the time

argued with Finkelstein in regard to the origin of most of the new settlers, but were also convinced that it was the crumbling cities on the one hand and the ever-growing pressure of the Egyptian overlords on the other that brought new settlers into the relative security offered by the no man’s land of the Samarian Highlands.

A conceptually very different scenario was suggested by Bunimovitz (1994). The point of departure for his reconstruction is the tightening of the Egyptian exploitation of the lowlands during the last part of the thirteenth and the first half of the twelfth centuries BCE. As a result, he claimed, the nomadic population that roamed the valleys was pushed into the highlands and had no other option than to settle down (see further below).

The publication of *From Nomadism to Monarchy* (Finkelstein and Na’aman 1994) was the culmination of a decade and a half of field operations and it aimed to stimulate further research. In reality, however, it marked the end of an era. As a result of the first Palestinian Intifada (1987–1989) and the Oslo Accords (1993), research on sites located in the Samarian Highlands ceased; no significant fieldwork has been conducted there since that time and no new data that could advance research there have become available. Scholarly attention and interest, however, has not waned. Scores of articles and books have been published since then. With few new data, these studies have mainly offered theoretical frameworks for interpreting previously available information. If anything, these articles have called for caution when evaluating the expression of identity through material culture (e.g., Bloch-Smith 2003). By observing the different components that make up the highlander’s material culture, scholars have questioned their use as ethnic markers. Four-room houses, collared-rim pithoi, and pig avoidance have been discussed and their status as identity markers has been found dubious at best (see Sapir-Hen in this issue and the introduction to this issue). As a result, the search for early Israel has moved from searching for identity markers to analyzing the formation of social complexity.

One thing has remained unchanged throughout the years: the dramatic expansion in the number of sites during the Iron I. Whether the growth of the monarchy of Israel was a social process, an identity transformation, or both, any fresh analysis of the evidence must start with explaining the reasons for this dramatic increase. Unfortunately, we have few new data regarding these sites: Their dating is still primarily based on pottery, and neither their economy nor their regional connections have ever been studied by natural, science-based methods.

Samarian Highlands: Settlement Oscillation

The outcome of the surveys conducted by Adam Zertal and Israel Finkelstein in the Samarian Highlands shows a very clear rise in the number of sites during the transition from the Late Bronze Age to the Iron I and in the highlands south and north of Shechem. Table 1 summarizes all available data from the published surveys conducted in the highlands.



Figure 3. The site of 'Isbet Šarṭah after reconstruction. The site was excavated as an example of a typical Israelite site. Courtesy of Israel Finkelstein.



Figure 4. A "courtyard" building at Megiddo Stratum VI. This building was part of a newly built city that preserved much of Megiddo's Canaanite nature. Courtesy of Israel Finkelstein and the Megiddo Expedition.



Figure 5. The site of Azekah was completely destroyed at the last third of the twelfth century BCE. Unlike many other sites mentioned in the article, Azekah did not recovered from this destruction and was resettled again only at the start of the Iron IIB. Courtesy of Oded Lipschits and Yuval Gadot, The Lautenschläger Azekah Expedition.

Table 1: Number of surveyed LB and Iron I sites in the Samarian Highlands as reported by Zertal and Finkelstein and Lederman

Subregion	LB	IA I	Reference
Southern Samaria	9 ¹	129	Finkelstein and Lederman 1997, 893–96
Shechem anticline	18 (15) ²	56	Zertal 2004, 53–55
Eastern Valleys	13 (9) ³	47	Zertal 2008, 82–86
Nahal'Iron to Shechem anticline	10 (6) ⁴	42	Zertal 2016, 38–41
From Nahal Bezeq to the Sartaba ⁵	11	60	Zertal 2005

Information regarding the overall settled hectares as calculated by Finkelstein shows that the rise was not just in the numbers of sites; it was a demographic rise as well. The uniqueness of the Iron I settlement pattern lies not only in the number of sites and overall settled territory but also in the expanse into previously sparsely inhabited parts of the highlands. The spatial distribution of sites dating to the Iron I shows they group into four clusters: The northernmost is located around Dothan Valley and seems to connect or at least interact with settlements located in the Jezreel Valley. A second cluster is located around Samaria and Shechem and interacts with contemporary sites located along Wadi el-Far'ah and the Jordan Valley. A third cluster is located farther south around Shiloh (fig. 2), and the fourth includes sites located on the Benjamin Plateau. Some of the sites, especially the ones located closer to the surrounding plains, show greater continuity between the Late Bronze Age and the Iron I. For example, of the twenty-four sites in the northern cluster, eight were also settled during the Late Bronze Age. On the other hand, only five of the thirty-six sites in the cluster around Samaria were settled previously.

Dating the start of the settlement wave is crucial in order to understand its context and the forces that may have triggered it. We have relatively detailed knowledge of the changing circumstances of the twelfth–eleventh centuries BCE. With this in hand, it is essential that we determine whether the settlement wave began before or after the Egyptian withdrawal and how it relates to the destruction and revival of Canaanite urban centers. Unfortunately, most if not all of the surveyed sites were dated in relative terms; indicative pottery collected from the surface to determine chronology resulted in dating that is by no means precise. Iron I pottery is in many ways a carryover from the Late Bronze Age and in regions of cultural continuity there is no real way to differentiate between the local potteries of the late thirteenth, twelfth, and eleventh centuries BCE. Hence, for example, Zertal's attempt to divide the sites into chronological stages should be taken

with caution (Zertal 1994, 58–59). A better approach would be to organize assemblages of the pottery of the excavated sites based on chronology, using absolute ^{14}C dates whenever possible (Finkelstein and Piazetsky 2006). The only site that has been dated by ^{14}C is Shiloh Stratum V, which was found to have been settled during first half of the eleventh century BCE. The dating of all other excavated sites, such as Mount Ebal or el-Ahwat, is considered relative to the pottery assemblage of Shiloh V, with some sites having being settled earlier (e.g., Giloh) and some later (e.g., 'Izbet Šarṭah II–I; fig. 3). Methodologically it must be remembered that it is always difficult to observe the beginnings of processes in the archaeological record, as they are obliterated by later activities. Therefore, without further field research, it can only be concluded that the wave of settlements had already begun in the twelfth century BCE and reached its zenith during the eleventh and tenth centuries BCE.



Figure 6. Tel Abel, Area A at the end of the 2018 season. In the picture it is possible to see walls dating to the Iron I period below later built Iron II walls. Excavations at the site revealed a strong and prosperous settlement dating to the Iron I. Photograph by Robert Mullins, courtesy of the Tel Abel Beth Maachah Excavations.

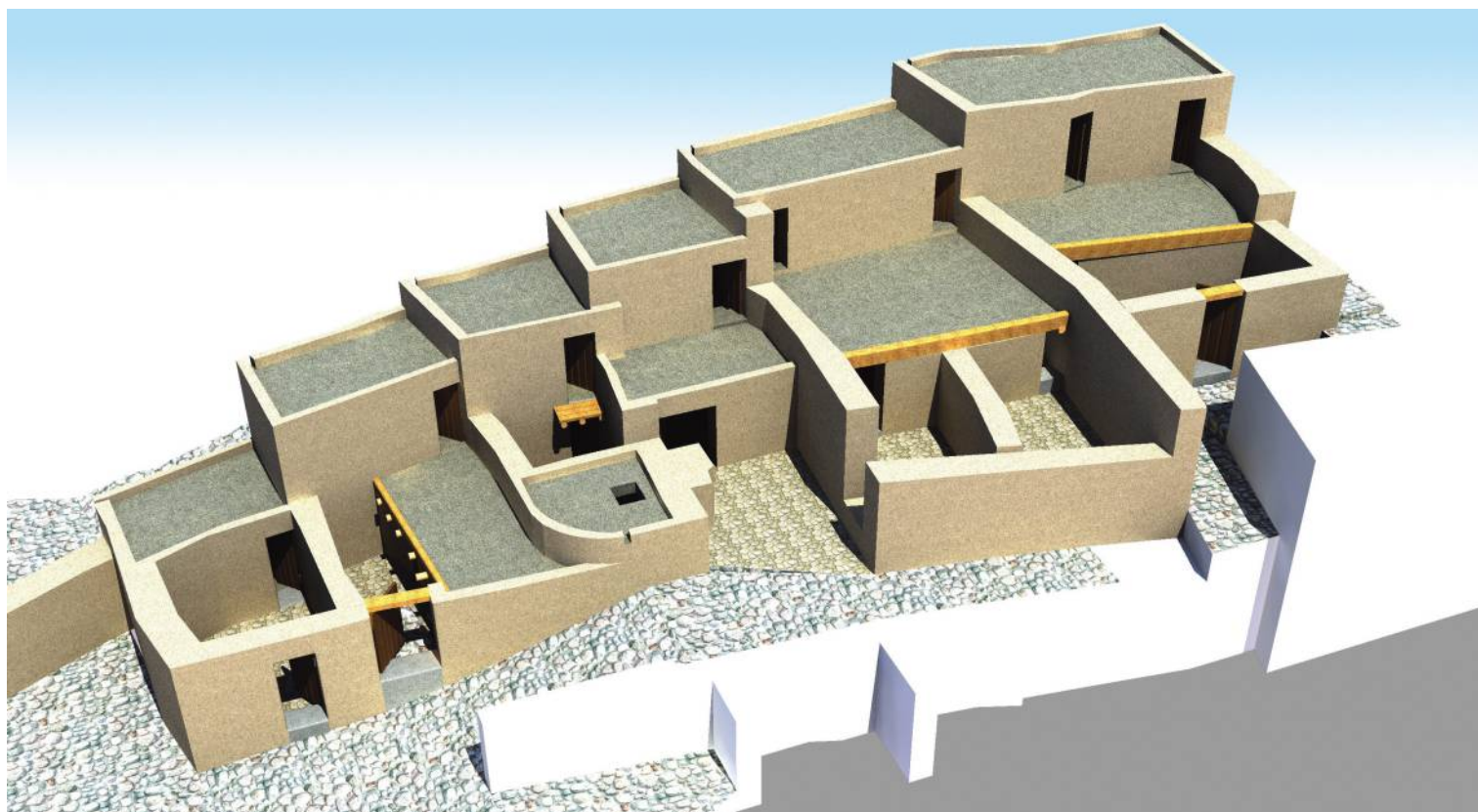


Figure 7. A 3D reconstruction of a well-planned living quarter at the site of Tel Kinrot. Courtesy of Christa Lennert and Bärbel Schöneweiss-Mehring, Kinneret Regional Project.



Figure 8. The preplanned Iron I site of Tel Hadar located at the eastern shores of the Sea of Galilee. The site was excavated by Moshe Kochavi and Perhiya Beck for Tel Aviv University. Courtesy of Assaf Kleiman and the Sonia and Marco Nadler Institute of Archaeology, Tel Aviv University.

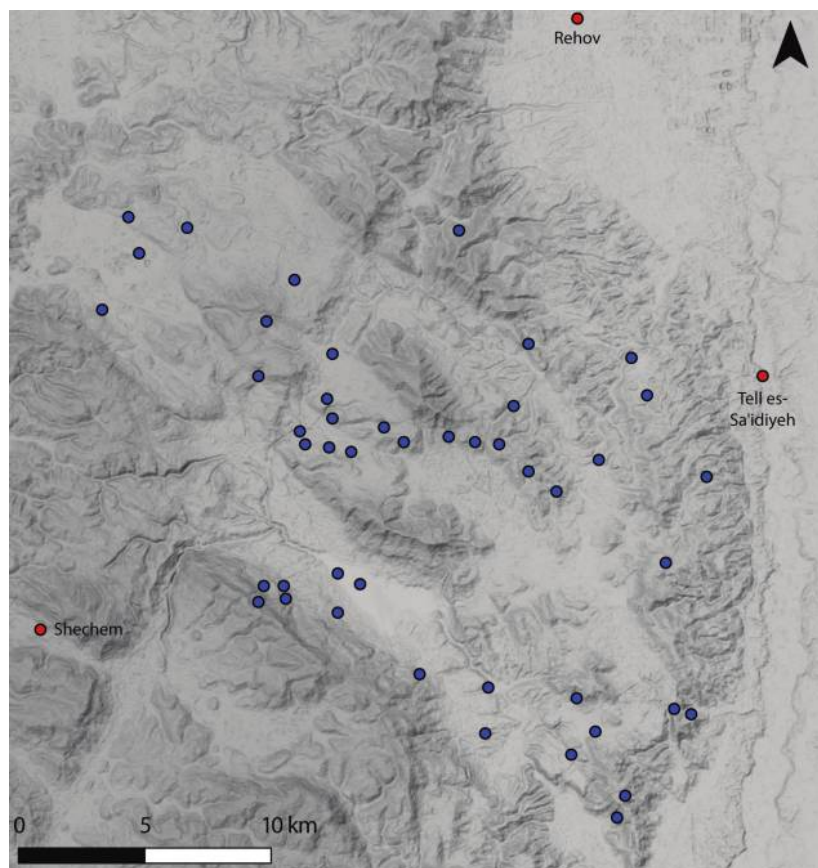


Figure 9. Map of all Iron I surveyed sites along Wadi Tizrah and the Jordan Valley and their relation to the urban sites of Shechem, Tel es Sa'idiyeh, and Rehov. Prepared by Assaf Kleiman.

Canaanite Urban Continuity

While the study of the archaeology of the Iron I Samarian Highlands has been in a state of frozen animation for the past twenty years, our understating of neighboring regions such as the Jezreel and Jordan Valleys as well as the Coastal Plain has completely changed.

The urban settlement pattern in the valleys west, north, and east of Samaria during the eleventh century BCE was noted by Finkelstein who pointed out the roles of Dor, Megiddo, Rehov, and Kinneret as major urban centers during the eleventh and tenth centuries BCE (Finkelstein 2003). Published research since then has only strengthened this observation. Intensive archeological research into the valleys in the north, the different parts making up the Coastal Plain and the Shephelah, has progressively altered our understanding of the fate of the Canaanite culture.

A key site for this new understanding of the twelfth and eleventh–tenth centuries is Megiddo. Stratum VIIA is considered by many to be the last of the “Late Bronze Age” cities at Megiddo. Its destruction was traditionally dated to roughly the middle of the twelfth century BCE. Recent work shows conclusively that the destruction should be placed at the end of that century, possibly even later and that the city did not experience wholesale destruction (Finkelstein et al. 2017). Research into the city’s economy shows intensification in its field and animal exploitation, a process that is associated with the continuity of Egyptian presence in Canaan.

The fact that Megiddo was partly destroyed so late means that its revival must have occurred more rapidly than previously realized and that by the mid-eleventh century the city had regained its strength. The new Stratum VI city was built along the same lines as the Late Bronze Age city, albeit on less grand scale. Stratum VIA was completely destroyed during the tenth century BCE, a destruction that marks the end of the “Canaanite” urban culture (fig. 4).

Megiddo is one example of a process that swept across the region during the twelfth–tenth centuries BCE. The early years saw an intensification of Egyptian control over parts of the country as its involvement became more direct. This included the establishment of small estates along the southern Coastal Plain and the strengthening and rebuilding of the fortresses at Jaffa and Beth-Shean. The nature and intensity of the interaction between the local Canaanite cities and the Egyptian-oriented sites differ from place to place, with some sites showing more direct Egyptian involvement while at others the association was more subtle.



Jordan Valley settlements came to typify urban centers. Sites such as Tel Rehov, Tall Zira'a and Tall Deir 'Alla began to exhibit cultural and political continuity in the transition from the Late Bronze Age into the Iron I (fig. 9). Work conducted around Megiddo shows the city was not isolated and that the western Jezreel Valley enjoyed a period of revitalization. Interregional and maritime trade were also resumed, as suggested by work conducted at Dor that brings to light its position as an entry port for commerce coming mainly from Egypt as well as other foreign lands. Sites such as Tel Keisan and Tel Qasile, Ashdod, Ashkelon, and probably Gaza show that Dor was not alone in its connection with maritime trade. Most cities, however, were more local in their economy and developed a primarily local exchange network. Cultural continuity is reported from Tel Gezer, Tel Beth-Shemesh, and Tel 'Eton. Farther to the southwest, the urban center of Ekron reached its zenith during the eleventh century, only to be replaced by the city of Gath. Closer to the end of the era the production of copper in the Arabah was resumed and this brought about large-scale changes in the settlement pattern of the Negev and the southern Coastal Plain. The inner region of the lower Shephelah, the former territory of Lachish, is the only region that did not recover from the years of political unrest.

Iron I Settlements in Context

The "Nomadism to Monarchy" theory attempted to explain the appearance of many sites across the Samarian Highlands as a reaction to the collapse of Canaanite urban culture. Whether settlers of the highlands who had always been there and only changed their subsistence strategy, or refugees from the decaying urban centers, the prime mover for settlement in the highlands is the collapse of urban society at the end of the Late Bronze Age. It seems that

The withdrawal of the Egyptian Empire from the southern Levant, dated by most scholars to the final decades of the twelfth century BCE, was followed by social unrest and destructive internal wars. Some sites experienced wholesale destruction (Lachish, Azekah) from which they recovered only after more than a century (fig. 5), and others were only partially destroyed (Megiddo). These were troubled years that saw power shifts between the traditional elite who relied on the Egyptian Empire for their authority and newer elites who based their legitimacy on local sources.

Within a few decades a new social order reached a balance and urban centers flourished across most of the land. The territory formerly controlled by Hazor became divided between at least two entities (Sergi and Kleiman 2018): one centered in the Hula Valley, which included major sites at Tell Abil el-Qameh (Abel Beth Maacah; fig. 6) and Tel Dan, and one centered around the Sea of Galilee and included the site of Tel Kinrot (fig. 7) and Tel Hadar (fig. 8).

these interpretations were bounded by the paradigm of a contest between the settlers of the lowlands and those of the highlands, a paradigm that is rooted in the narrative of the Book of Judges. While these antagonistic relations are probably true for the end of the process, that is, the transition to the Iron IIA and the rise of the territorial states (see Sergi in this issue), there is no reason to assume they also characterize the beginning of the process.

The review presented here shows conclusively that Canaanite urbanism did not collapse but rather went through a period of turmoil. At the end of the thirteenth century and beginning of the twelfth century BCE some Canaanite centers and Egyptian strongholds were destroyed. Most centers, however, quickly recovered and were rebuilt and Egyptian hegemony over the land became more direct. A second wave of destructions accompanied the Egyptian withdrawal close to the end of the twelfth century but the eleventh and tenth centuries BCE were a period of independent and evolving urbanism (fig. 10).

The lack of absolute chronology for the wave of settlements in the Samarian Highlands makes it difficult to correlate this phenomenon with either the twelfth century BCE—the time of intensified Egyptian hegemony—or the eleventh century BCE—the period of the independent urban system. Two previous attempts have been made to connect the intensification of Egyptian exploitation during the twelfth century BCE and the initiation of settlements across the highlands. According to Bunimovitz, the takeover of arable lands in the Jezreel and other valleys by the Egyptians pushed the nomadic population into the highlands, where they settled down (Bunimovitz 2014). This explanation maintains the antagonistic relations between the neighboring regions but acknowledges the fact that the twelfth century BCE was not an era of crisis.

Bunimovitz's scenario failed to address the question of the eleventh–tenth centuries BCE. If indeed the settlers were pushed out of Egyptian-controlled lands, what happened after the Egyptians left and the lands once again became available? What prevented the highland population from leaving the highlands in order to exploit the vacant valleys again? David Wengrow's (1996) model also connected the settlement wave with Egyptian presence, but, according to his suggestion, the sites were not the outcome of forced settlement but rather the opposite: The sites formed part of an Egyptian colony that exploited these formally uninhabited lands (see also Knauf 2017). It seems that this explanation oversimplifies the complex reality, especially with regard to the eleventh and tenth centuries BCE. Wengrow based his model on the assumption that most of the sites dated to the twelfth century BCE and that these colonies collapsed when the Egyptians withdrew. There is no basis whatsoever for this assumption as some, if not most, of the sites date to the eleventh and early tenth centuries. However, Wengrow was the first to view the highlands settlements as an integral part of the social and political system that ruled over the lowlands and to claim that the two regions were symbiotic. An example for such a symbiotic relationship can be seen in the associations that developed between settlements located along the Yarkon River (for example Tel Qasile and Tel Aphek) and sites located along the western slopes of southern Samaria such as 'Izbet Šarṭah. The

Accumulated wealth at 'Izbet Šarṭah next to Building 109 may be a reflection of the owner's role as a middleman in an exchange of grains and orchard produce between Shiloh and Coastal Plain sites.

It seems that the eleventh century BCE urban reality, ignored by most scholars until now, is the key to understanding the settlement wave. When placed in its archaeological context, the settlement surge in the Samarian Highlands becomes an integral part of the settlement surge all across the land. Cities located in different regions of the country stabilized the rural sector and fostered agricultural activities in places located farther and farther afield. It is possible that the settlement wave had already begun in the twelfth century BCE in reaction to the intensive Egyptian estate system that directly exploited the fertile lowlands. In that case, just as the Canaanite cities prospered despite the Egyptian withdrawal, so did the rural sites across the Samarian Highlands.

Previous scholarship regarding the Samarian Highlands settlements viewed these sites as consisting of seminomadic or displaced populations that had been pressed into settlement in the region as a result of the collapse of the Late Bronze Age society. Even when scholars realized that the Canaanite urban culture had not collapsed at all, Iron I settlement in the highlands was viewed as an isolated phenomenon and one that was antagonistic to the surrounding regions.

In view of our current knowledge, it is clear that the settlement surge into the Samarian Highlands was not a unique process that stood in isolation from demographic and settlement processes that took place in other regions. On the contrary, the reviving urban centers and regional and interregional trading relations fostered rural exploitation and a rise in the number of sites. The highlands of Samaria were no exception. Surrounded by a flourishing urban landscape from the east, north, and west, the valleys and hills of Samaria were progressively taken over by permanent settlements.

Finkelstein claimed that the dramatic rise in the number of settlements during the Iron I should be viewed as part of long-range cyclic processes taking place over thousands of years. He recognized two earlier settlement waves dating to the Early and Middle Bronze Ages. In both periods, the rise in the number of settlements corresponded to a rise in urbanism. This was especially true for the MB II. Apparently, the fact that the Iron I settlement oscillation happened parallel to yet another rise in urbanism better explains it as a cyclic event within a long-range socio-demographic process. It seems that, throughout history, a stable urban system in the lower and fertile lands brought with it a rise in rural activities in the Samarian Highlands. The Late Bronze Age stands as an exception, probably because of the burden of Egyptian rule. Over four hundred years of economic and social exploitation drained the country of its limited resources. While some families enjoyed a monopoly over the relations with the Egyptians, which helped them gain wealth and power, most of the country was neglected and the rural sector became depopulated. As the Egyptians withdrew, some of the urban and tribal elite lost their standing as new power centers took their place. As the years passed, a new urban landscape evolved hand in hand with an expansion of rural settlements. This autonomic growth was gradual until it reached

its culmination at the end of the Iron I. By then these entities were strong enough to begin competing for control and resources, marking the onset of a new chapter.

Notes

1. Only definite sites were counted (Late Bronze–Iron I or Iron I–II were excluded).
2. In index 6 (list of sites by periods) fifteen sites are listed as dating to the LBIIIB.
3. In index 6 (list of sites by periods) nine sites are listed as dating to the LBIII.
4. In index 7 (list of sites by periods) six sites are listed as dating to the LBIII.
5. This book presents sites that are located at the southern edge of the Beth Shean Valley, the Jordan Valley and the flood plains of Wadi el Far'ah. It seems that it represents sites that are the periphery of Tel Rehov (the northern cluster) and Wadi el Far'ah (the southern cluster). In the Late Bronze Age the northern cluster includes eight sites that grow into 11 in the Iron I. The southern cluster moves from one to 49 (Zertal 2005, 64–69).

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